

What is Virtual Reality (VR)?

VR is the creation of a simulated environment. The view for the user has shifted from the screen in front of them. With VR, they are immersed in a 3D world where they can indulge as many of their senses as possible - everything from hearing, vision, touch and even the smells they experience are simulated for them. The only real limiting factors for VR are the easy availability of cheap computing power and engaging content.

The 2018 movie 'Ready Player One', based on a 2011 novel by the same name, showcases VR beautifully and is a fantastic example of how VR has been capturing the minds of more than just tech nerds.

What is Augmented Reality (AR)?

AR allows for the integration of digital information along with the user's physical environment in real time. Unlike VR that is based on creating an entirely artificial environment, AR will use the existing environment of the user and will overlay information atop it.

The easiest example of AR that has taken the world by storm is perhaps Snapchat lenses. Even the game Pokemon Go uses AR smartly to make the user engaged and increase the game's sticky factor. It did get people highly addicted for a while, didn't it?

Which is Better?

This is a question that had most industry analysts stumped initially. There were two clear cut camps, with big companies like Facebook and Google putting their money down. AR and VR have always been expected to grow at different rates. Initially it seemed like VR had caught the fancy of the world. With names like Google, Facebook, Samsung and Sony rushing to put their weight behind this technology, it wasn't long before the market saw an influx of futuristic headsets that were being designed to ensure everyone could experience the magic of VR.

VR Too Costly

Despite all the muscle and the money pouring in to support VR, it still has not gained the kind of momentum one would have hoped for (especially if you are Mark Zuckerberg). There are common pitfalls that all these VR producing companies faced - cost of the hardware being extremely high, thus making it unaffordable for the masses. A lot of users in the trial stage complained of motion sickness. Given the dearth of consumer interest, not